

Ken Burns's
THE
CIVIL
WAR

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**Historians
Respond**
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EDITED BY
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IN SEPTEMBER 1990, *The Civil War* made television history. The eleven-hour series broke the PBS audience-record for an educational series (*Cosmos*, Carl Sagan's 1980 program, had been the previous leader). In many metropolitan areas it attracted more viewers than the regular entertainment fare on the major networks. An estimated 13.9 million Americans watched *The Civil War*'s first broadcast, and many more tuned into later programs (about 40 million watched one or more broadcasts). Then millions more saw subsequent broadcasts on TV, purchased videos, or viewed the series in connection with school, college, or adult education classes. Additional millions enthusiastically watched *The Civil War* when it appeared on television in Great Britain, Germany, Japan, and other nations. The series also had a spillover effect in the United States, stirring the public's hunger for knowledge

about the war. In the weeks and months after broadcast, attendance at Civil War battle sites rose significantly, and books about the subject sold briskly. One author who profited from the bonanza was Shelby Foote, the historian who appeared in several of Burns's episodes. Foote told Burns the documentary turned him into "a millionaire." He had sold 30,000 copies of his war trilogy in fifteen years; during the six months after the broadcast, Foote sold more than 100,000 sets.

The Civil War's popularity brought Ken Burns an attractive overture from Disney Studios suggesting that Burns come to California and explore opportunities in commercial filmmaking. The 37-year-old filmmaker did not accept the invitation, however, choosing to remain in New Hampshire to continue production of historical documentaries. He followed *The Civil War* with *Empire of the Air: The Men Who Made Radio*, and in 1994 released *Baseball*, a film that rivaled *The Civil War* in ambition and breadth of coverage.

Ken Burns had become interested in filmmaking during his years as a student at Hampshire College, an institution whose founders aimed to foster student creativity through an innovative learning environment. In Burns's case they clearly succeeded. In Burns's last year at Hampshire he presented a sophisticated documentary as his senior thesis, a film about Old Sturbridge Village (a restored New England community). After graduation, Burns established Florentine Films with some college buddies, naming the firm after a nearby Massachusetts town where a favorite teacher lived. Burns's interest in American history was evident in the themes he chose for subsequent documentaries (interestingly, he had taken only one history course in college and that in Russian history). *Brooklyn Bridge* (1982), his first major production, garnered

an Academy Award nomination and numerous awards. The production featured historian David McCullough as narrator (McCullough had written an important book on the history of the bridge's construction). This collaboration established a long-term friendship and placed McCullough as a familiar commentator in Burns's productions (including *The Civil War*). Several documentaries followed: *The Shakers: Hands to Work, Hearts to God* (1984); *Huey Long* (1985); *The Statue of Liberty* (1985); *Thomas Hart Benton* and *The Congress* (1988).

A stipulation in the grant from the National Endowment for the Humanities, which propelled initial planning for *The Civil War*, demanded collaboration between creative artists and scholars. Such cooperation was familiar to Burns (he had worked closely with historians in all of his previous documentary projects), but it led to friction in the early stages of discussions regarding *The Civil War*. Burns encountered significant resistance from some individuals attending an advisory board meeting. On one occasion when the historians gathered to review a first draft of the script, a few of them complained that the document related an old-fashioned nineteenth-century version of the Civil War story by giving too much attention to military affairs. Burns explained that the draft was a working document, that he welcomed his advisers' recommendations, and that the production team intended to make use of the advisers' suggestions in subsequent drafts. C. Vann Woodward, a participant in that meeting and defender of Burns in the heated discussions, offered a pointed response at the meeting (see Woodward's description in this book).

As the film began to take shape, PBS officials, corporate underwriters, and book publishers sensed the quality of the forthcoming production and conjectured that broadcast of

The Civil War could draw considerable viewer attention. Administrators at PBS agreed to highlight the production with an unusual format: they would run programs in the series back-to-back on consecutive nights for an entire week (ABC had been tremendously successful with similar programming strategy in the 1970s in its broadcast of the historical drama *Roots*). Publicity for *The Civil War* was essential, since not all that many Americans were in a habit of watching documentaries on PBS Television. General Motors responded handsomely to this challenge, providing \$1.5 million for promotion. Furthermore, publishing executives realized that a successful TV series about the greatest tragedy in American history would be likely to stimulate spinoff sales of print materials. They agreed to pay a \$375,000 advance for a lavishly illustrated book related to the series. While all of this pre-broadcast activity revealed an expectation of success, before September 1990 the major underwriters and Burns himself did not fully sense that they were dealing with a unique phenomenon: a documentary about to prove itself a blockbuster.

During the week of broadcast, the topic of the Civil War became a familiar subject of conversation in homes, schools, workplaces, bars, and commuter trains. Thousands of letters from excited fans poured into Burns's office at Florentine Films, as enthusiasts eloquently described their emotional reactions to the film and related information about their ancestors' experiences in the Civil War. Burns was an instant celebrity. He appeared on the Johnny Carson show and had to deal with hero-worshippers who mobbed him in public places.

Why did *The Civil War* make such an extraordinary impact? Why did viewer enthusiasm soar well beyond interest in hundreds of other historical documentaries that appeared on American television in previous years?

Certainly, the subject matter contributed to the success. No topic from U.S. history had excited as much curiosity from Americans and foreigners as the sectional conflict of 1861–65. The war represented the only situation in U.S. history in which Americans could not work out their differences within the political system and turned instead to killing each other under separate flags and governments. The subject also excited interest because of the carnage associated with it. More than 600,000 Americans perished in the war. Two days at the Shiloh battlefield resulted in more deaths than in all previous American wars. One day at Antietam became the bloodiest in American history. It is not surprising, then, that readers have long demonstrated curiosity about this great national tragedy.

Still, the public's hunger for information about the Civil War could not alone explain why the broadcast became an important event in the history of education-oriented television. Numerous other documentaries and docudramas dealing with themes from the Civil War era had appeared on TV, yet they did not come close to arousing the audience response that Burns's film did. Clearly, much of the success of the series related to Burns's skills as a filmmaker. The young artist had managed to present his subject in a fascinating way.

Burns demonstrated that he was an extraordinarily effective craftsman of film, and the popularity of the series may be attributed in large part to his skills as a communicator. Burns had established his own technique by 1990, a style of presenting history on television that became his own artistic signature. Other filmmakers employed aspects of his method, but Burns developed a reputation for orchestrating these technical elements with particular elegance and sophistication. One hallmark of his work concerned the rejection of fictional elements and concentration on authentic evidence from the past.

In making *The Civil War*, for example, Burns did not incorporate re-enactments by modern-day figures dressed as soldiers or feature actors in period costumes or draw upon dramatic excerpts from Hollywood movies. Instead, he focused on authentic sources from the war—photographs, lithographs, paintings, newspapers, letters, signs, handbills, and other items. His handling of photographs was masterful, for the primitive photography of the 1860s required that subjects stand still and pose (cameras had not been fast enough then to capture movement effectively). *The Civil War* injected life in these visual documents, nonetheless, by examining them as an art historian would scan a painting. With considerable sensitivity, the camera read messages from the pictures, focusing on specific elements of the images while words, sounds, and music provided accent. Burns's camera also took the viewer to the modern-day locales of the battlefields, using present-day cinematography to show the sites where tragedy had occurred in the 1860s. Sometimes the camera rushed across a ridge or weaved between trees in the woods, giving audiences a feeling for the terror soldiers experienced as they dodged unseen enemies. At other moments Burns quietly studied a windy field while the film encouraged viewers to ponder life in a distant time in history. Interestingly, Burns often succeeded in stirring the viewer's imagination while showing modern-day physical settings devoid of human figures.

The mystery of this achievement becomes less baffling when we recognize that *The Civil War* offered its audiences much more than just a visual experience. A great deal of the film's communication came through the medium of sound. Ambient noise of horses' galloping, cannons' firing, and men screaming punctuated the story while the camera concentrated

on photos or present-day battle sites. Music also carried messages and contributed to the sense of authenticity. Throughout the series, audiences heard the tunes that moved soldiers and citizens of the war era, such as "Battle Hymn of the Republic," "Rally Round the Flag, Boys," and "Dixie." One of the most memorable melodies, a refrain with a haunting suggestion of life in the nineteenth century, was actually created in the late twentieth century. Composer Jay Ungar wrote "Ashokan Farewell," the remarkable piece that served as the principal musical theme for *The Civil War*.

Words were also essential in the documentary. Burns presented much of his story in the language of the people who lived through the wartime experience. He had begun experimenting with these "quotations" as a young filmmaker in college, and, through the years, Burns has given them prominent places in his films. *The Civil War* incorporated over 900 quotations. Many were familiar to readers of books about the war, such as Lincoln's observation, "If there's a worse place than hell, I'm in it," and an African-American's comment during the war when his fortunes improved: "Hello, massa. Bottom rail on top this time." Numerous other quotations from the era were less well known, and their appearance in the film reflected the successful research efforts of Burns and his fellow researchers. One of the interesting discoveries concerned the diary of Elisha Hunt Rhodes, which Burns had bought from a fellow townsman after finding it in an antique shop. Burns considered the Rhodes diary wonderfully evocative of the thoughts of a Union soldier, and he gave Rhodes's observations a prominent place in the film.

Technical artistry was critical to Burns's success in making history appealing, but there was another essential element that

was psychological rather than technical. Burns managed to help viewers *feel* the experience of war.

When speaking about his efforts to produce *The Civil War*, Ken Burns called himself “a historian of emotions.” Emotion “is the great glue of history,” he said, the cement that makes the meaning of facts stick in viewers’ minds. Film not only presents information; it sharpens the audience’s sense of the importance of the facts. It “has the power to reach profound levels of emotion,” Burns pointed out, “and I can’t be interested in a piece of history unless there’s something I can loosely describe as emotional about it. I think the ordinary person feels that way too.” Burns argued that film is not primarily about dates and facts. “It is *all* about people and their passions.”

A good illustration of Burns’s attention to the emotional dimension of history can be seen toward the end of the first program. In that segment audiences heard a reading of the now-famous letter Sullivan Ballou wrote to his wife shortly before he died in the first battle at Bull Run. Ballou’s words appeared against a background of beautiful cinematography showing the fields where the Yankee figure fell. This moment in the film brought many viewers to tears. It evoked sensitivity to the tragedy at Bull Run more effectively than narration or visual presentations could.

Several of the program’s most memorable emotion-laden moments occurred toward the end of the series. The presentation of Lincoln’s visit to the Confederate capital of Richmond in the last days of the war, particularly the treatment of Lincoln’s decision to sit at the desk of the Confederate leader Jefferson Davis, was emotionally powerful. So was the portrayal of Robert E. Lee’s surrender to Ulysses S. Grant at Appomattox. Even more memorable was the presentation of John Wilkes Booth’s assassination of Lincoln at Ford’s Theatre. Burns se-

cured the services of a Washington acting team for a reading of the play, *Our American Cousin*, which the President witnessed on his last night. As television viewers heard words from the Victorian comedy and saw the interior of Ford’s Theatre, they encountered painful hints of the tragedy about to unfold. Burns’s technique drew the viewers’ emotions into the historical scene, giving them the impression of being present in the past.

The achievement in arousing feeling for history was particularly encouraging to educators, because Burns delivered this stimulus through the medium of television. TV had received much criticism since the 1950s for failing to live up to the promise that its early enthusiasts suggested (many had thought it would prove a tremendous instrument for education). Critics complained about television’s presentation of the lowest common denominator in entertainment, observing the prominence of crime and comic drama on TV and the relative scarcity of sophisticated, mind-stimulating programming. Many concluded that entertainment and education could not mix well in American-style television, and they looked to books as far better sources of understanding. The success of *The Civil War* seemed to challenge this negative conclusion. It appeared to demonstrate that television had the potential to entertain and educate at the same time.

While Burns accomplished a great deal through television, it is important to recognize, too, that his filmed perspective on history did not present a full account of the Civil War experience. Many elements in the story were absent in his documentary or received only limited attention. To identify what was missing or got brief consideration is not necessarily to criticize the filmmaker. No television documentary can be expected to provide a truly comprehensive treatment of a his-

torical subject. There are not enough broadcast hours to “cover” all relevant subjects adequately. A script of the words spoken in an hour-long documentary may amount to no more than a dozen to twenty pages—a relatively small information load. Film “is not equipped to do what a book does,” admits Burns, “which is to attain profound levels of meaning and texture.” Burns sees film as a stimulus to interest. A television program can excite the viewers’ curiosity, he says, and stir them to seek depth of knowledge through further reading.

While film is an attractive medium for showing dramatic confrontations and violent action, it is often less successful in communicating concepts or exploring ideas in depth. Film can effectively relate the personal side of the past, introducing audiences to individuals from history, but it is often disappointing when analyzing broad trends. Both in documentaries and docudramas, filmmakers usually concentrate on personalities and their impact on history, giving much less attention to impersonal forces. Filmmakers know, for instance, that broad economic changes often make a profound impact on people’s lives. They sense, however, that reporting on such a topic does not tend to involve audiences. Filmmakers realize that their productions are more likely to prove appealing if they concentrate on telling interesting stories about the way specific people effected change through the force of individual personalities and actions.

We can regret the absence of a more thorough discussion of impersonal factors, but in wishing for greater comprehensiveness we should not lose sight of the distinctive character of history on film. It is not the same as history on the printed page. If filmmakers try to touch every popular issue briefly, they are likely to confuse or bore their audiences. Rather than attempt to present a visual encyclopedia, documentarists usually

focus on particular subjects. They give attention to the highly dramatic elements in history. Filmmakers understand, for example, that scenes of tension and conflict are likely to attract audience interest. It is not surprising, then, that Burns’s compelling documentary concentrated on war themes, subjects that work well for TV.

Evidence of this pattern can be seen in the emphasis of the series on the story of generals, soldiers, and battles. Burns devoted much less study to the home front and to subjects such as industrialization, finance, inflation, and the draft. Issues regarding dissent during wartime received scant attention as did decisions by the Supreme Court. These subjects were addressed, to be sure, but to a lesser degree. Also, the important topic of foreign policy received minor attention, especially the significant subject of the Confederacy’s attempts to gain recognition from France and from Great Britain. Women made appearances throughout the programs by way of the quotations from Mary Boykin Chesnut and reports on the wartime activities of Clara Barton and Dorothea Dix. Their cameos were “politically correct” for 1990, but the series did not move far beyond mini-biographies and general remarks. Some aspects of the fighting also received only brief attention. For instance, after presenting a graphic description of the battle between the *Monitor* and the *Merrimack*, relatively little else was said about naval warfare. Only a little was reported on the important Union blockade of Confederate ports, the role of southern blockade runners, or the significance of ironclads after the *Monitor-Merrimack* confrontation.

While examining the contributors’ assessments of Burns’s treatment of history, readers ought to consider some of the fundamental questions about interpreting history on film that these observations suggest. As mentioned above, for example,

the documentary presents some aspects of the Civil War in colorful detail while giving only limited attention to other elements. Is this selectiveness justified? Would the film have been better had Burns given more time to the issues of interest to the authors in this book? Does the absence of greater attention to the suggested subjects reflect significant problems in the film's perspective on the Civil War? Or, do the critics expect too much? Shouldn't Burns have the right to interpret the war in terms of the issues he considers important? Can we appreciate the artist's interest in concentrating on stories that appear to work well on film and leave for books the subjects that work less well for the visual medium? Indeed, shouldn't Burns's critics recognize that no single documentary can provide a completely comprehensive picture of the war? If there are gaps in the film under study, is not the appropriate remedy to seek production of *other* films about the war years that accent *other* perspectives rather than to demand a different product from Burns?

If the opinions registered in this book are highly judgmental, it is because scholars believe that the stakes are very high. *The Civil War* is no ordinary documentary. It aroused interest in history as no other recent educational film has. The extraordinary reception demonstrated that a single television series could stimulate millions of people in the United States and the world to think seriously about the experiences of the past. In short, debates about *The Civil War* became intense, because the documentary represented perhaps the best modern American example of film's potential to teach history on a mass scale. In holding Burns's production to high scholarly standards, then, the contributors have acknowledged the significance of his accomplishment.